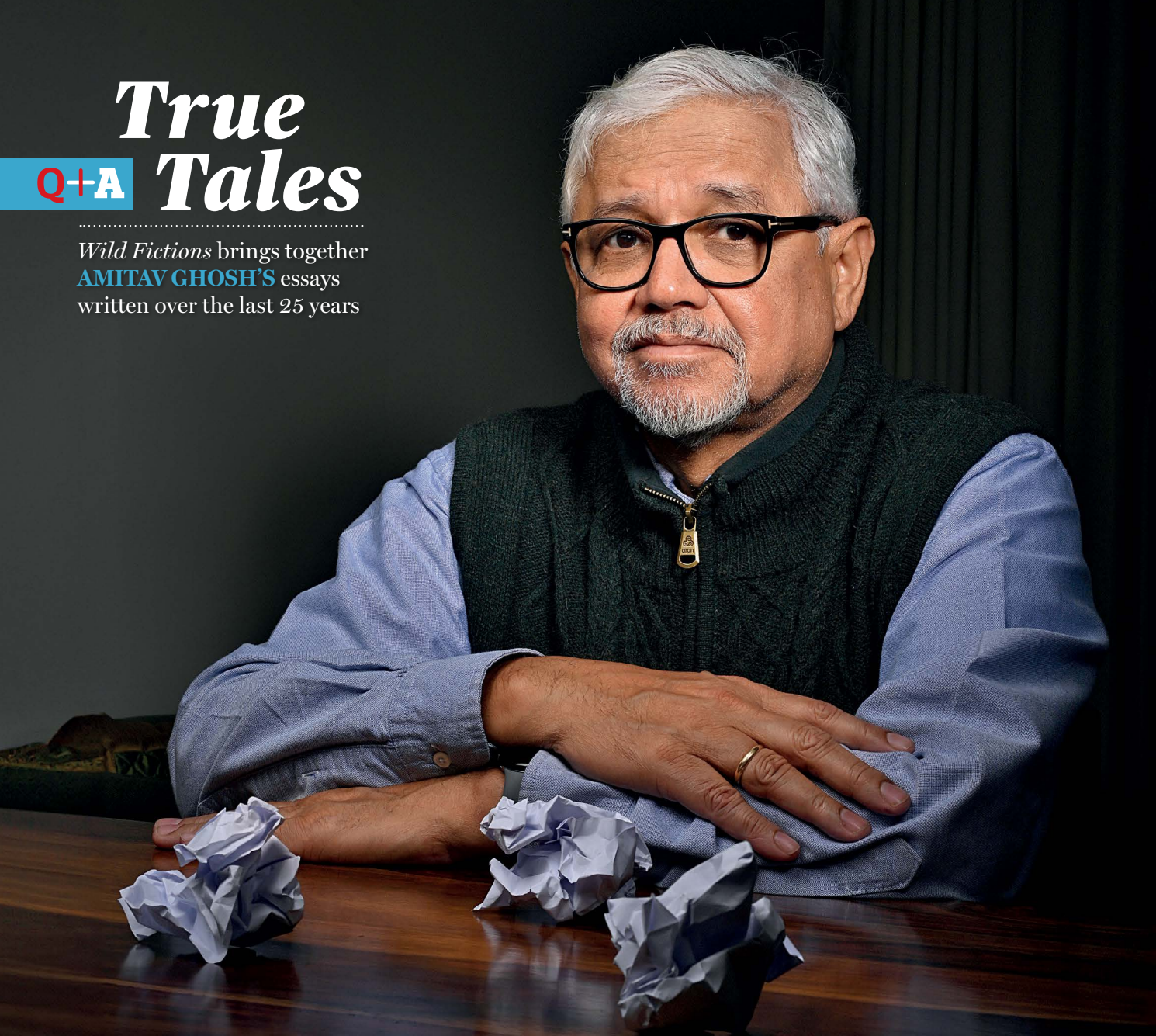
Q+A

True Tales

Wild Fictions brings together **AMITAV GHOSH'S** essays written over the last 25 years



Q. Why did you choose to call a collection of non-fiction pieces *Wild Fictions*?

Many of these essays are about stories, and how they shape our understanding of, and interactions with, the world around us. I've contrasted the view of 'nature' that emerged in Europe in the wake of the Enlightenment, as a domain that was separate from the world of humans, with the entirely different perspective of people who live in proximity to forests, rivers and oceans.

Q. Is there an overarching theme uniting the essays?

The theme that runs through most of them is that of bearing witness to a rupture in time, of chronicling the passing of an era that began 300 years ago, in the 18th century.

Q. What is your most pressing concern as a writer now?

Once you become aware that the planet is in the grip of an unprecedented and multidimensional crisis, you cannot blank that out. Climate change is one dimension of this crisis. Biodiversity loss, the advent of new pathogens, geopolitical turmoil...are equally important dimensions of our crisis. Everything I write now is informed by this awareness.

Q. Are there any essays here you're particularly fond of?

Three of them are based on Bengali documents written by medical personnel who were in the Mesopotamian campaign during World War I. Writing them was very rewarding, partly because the sources were very different from any that I had used before, and partly because I originally wrote them as blog posts.

Q. What else are you working on at the moment?

I'm working on a novel. I've written a lot of non-fiction over the last few years, so it's good to get back to fiction again.

Photograph by RAJWANT RAWAT

–with Amit Dixit